By Jeemon Jacob

KERALA/ HUMAN SACRIFICE

SATAN'S OWN COUNTRY?

Kerala has always been a land of incongruities, with revolution and superstition living side by side in a state that claims to have achieved 100 per cent literacy long ago. Nor is it a stranger to bizarre cases involving sordid sex or murder. But last week's shocker at Elanthoor in Pathanamthitta district, where two women were killed as part of a 'human sacrifice', with cannibalism being alleged, rocked even the more resolute among god's own citizens.

Confessions of the main accused, alleged black magic practitioner Mohammed Shafi, 52, revealed that he lured two women lottery vendors—Padmam, 52, from Ernakulam, and Sicily, 50, from Kalady—and took them to the house of local healer Bhagaval Singh, 64, and his second wife Laila, 57, in Elanthoor, where they were beheaded and their bodies chopped into several parts in a ritual sacrifice for the couple's prosperity.

According to the Kochi police, the victims were cut into 56 pieces, and buried in four pits. The couple have also allegedly confessed to cooking and eating certain body parts, as instructed by Shafi. The postmortem report and forensic examination at the crime site confirmed the story, say the police. "The investigation is progressing. Shafi is not cooperating now, but we are cross-verifying the information we have got so far," says H. Nagaraj, Kochi city police commissioner. This is not Shafi's first offence. He was jailed in 2020 for raping a 75-year-old woman.

Deputy commissioner S. Sasidharan, who followed up on the missing persons case involving Padmam, led the 12-day investigation that solved the twin murders. Padmam, who stayed in a rented room in Kochi, had disappeared on September 26.



AS SATHEESH

BLACK MAGIC Main accused Mohammed Shafi in court

The police cyber cell locked in on her frequent callers and went through hundreds of hours of CCTV footage till the breakthrough came via a clip of her getting into a Scorpio SUV, the one that had taken her from Ernakulam to Elanthoor. Call records helped identify the final destination. The police found that both Padmam and Shafi were in one tower location on September 26 when the victim's mobile was switched off.

"The Kochi police did a brilliant job. Normally such missing persons cases are disposed of without proper investigation as the victims are poor. But here, they followed up on every lead to wrap up the case," says retired DGP Vinson M. Paul.

THE TWO WOMEN VICTIMS WERE KILLED AS PART OF A 'HUMAN SACRIFICE', WITH EVEN CANNIBALISM BEING ALLEGED

With the spotlight on missing women/ children, DGP Anil Kant has directed the district police chiefs to re-investigate all such unsolved cases. Police records suggest that the state had 473